



Case Study: Embedded Policy Fellow Dan Olnier

Celebrating collaboration successes throughout the region

AT A GLANCE

Dan Olnier is a Y-PERN Policy Fellow from the University of Sheffield who has been seconded into South Yorkshire Mayoral Combined Authority (SYMCA) to work alongside their officers. Dan has brought a new skillset where capacity has been limited.

Key Metrics



10

EXPLAINER TALKS & PRESENTATIONS



11

OUTPUTS SUCH AS EXPLAINER GUIDES, MAPS & RESOURCES



ONE

COMPANIES HOUSE DASHBOARD



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POLICY FELLOW OBJECTIVES



Dan Olnier's initial work with SYMCA was undertaken in support of their 'Good Growth Plan'. The primary objective was to carry out data analysis to understand how South Yorkshire's economy has evolved over time and how it compares to the rest of the UK, particularly from a sectoral perspective. This analysis aimed to help SYMCA develop and articulate a coherent economic story of how South Yorkshire reached its current position.

A secondary objective was to create a sustainable repository of regional analysis tools built using open data and reproducible methods, enabling ongoing exploration of economic patterns and supporting capacity building across local and strategic authorities.

A CONNECTED APPROACH



Dan's physical presence and regular contact with SYMCA officers has meant analysis can be shaped iteratively through conversations, rather than being commissioned at a distance and delivered months later. As one fellow describes it, "the policy environment changes massively faster than academia". But embedding expertise within a Combined Authority allows the fellows to work at that pace and adjust as priorities shift.



"Y-PERN has helped strengthen links between our region's universities and the MCA, ensuring we have better access to expertise to support evidence-led decision-making. Via the Policy Fellow initiative we've been lucky to host a Y-PERN Policy Fellow. This support and partnership has been great for introducing new data insights into our work, particularly in developing the region's economic strategy, and strengthening our organisation's analytical capability at a time when our work is rapidly changing and growing."

Alice Rubbra, Assistant Director, Growth, Business and Skills Strategy, South Yorkshire Mayoral Authority



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PROJECT OUTCOMES



The work fostered trusting relationships with SYMCA and other stakeholders, leading to ongoing collaboration and integration into future projects. Physical presence and regular contact proved crucial, allowing the work to adapt at the pace of policy change and adjust as priorities shifted. This embedded approach also enabled linkages that built connections across multiple stakeholders, including SYMCA, four local authorities, two universities, consultants, and external organisations. Dan's work produced a comprehensive repository of regional analysis tools that allow his colleagues to explore patterns in GVA, jobs, and productivity across sectors and places. The project generated a series of outputs including work on business dynamism, the low carbon renewable energy economy, and individual firm-level data analysis. Collaboration with ONS Local emerged as a significant outcome, including presentations at their regional conference and the development of workshops to support capacity building across other local and strategic authorities.

Building Transparency & Capability

Using open data and reproducible methods has helped avoid the "black box" problem that often comes with external consultancy. Dan's colleagues can explore, interrogate and re-use the tools he has built, which supports in-house capability growth rather than overreliance on external actors

Trust Building & Expanding Networks

New connections continue to grow, building on these trusting relationships. For example, recent links have been made with Sheffield Innovation Spine and Tech SY. Within SYMCA, the fellows are working with the insights team to build links with the growth group to deepen understanding of sector connections within South Yorkshire.



Through Y-PERN, the toolkit has been applied beyond South Yorkshire to Leeds, Bradford, York, North Yorkshire, and Yorkshire and The Humber as a whole. Dan's work has also supported analysis of the impact of AI on jobs in Greater Manchester.



"Being physically embedded in SYMCA's Sheffield office has enabled a high level of day-to-day collaboration with policy teams. This has enabled a shift from thinking (somewhat patronisingly) about universities 'transmitting expertise' into policy spaces to working alongside officers (who are themselves experts in their domains) to co-produce analysis and questions that support decision-making."

Dan Olnier, Y-PERN Policy Fellow



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